

Grammar Essentials and Error Spotting

Chapter F8.4 — A Finite List of Patterns, Which Is Why This Chapter Can Be Finished Quickly

Module	Foundation Layer — Module 8 — English, Quantitative Aptitude & Reasoning
Chapter	Chapter F8.4
Topic	Official syllabus head A — General English
Version	v1.0
Compiled	16 August 2026
Exam stage	Recruitment Test (RT)

NOTE · THE HONEST WEIGHTING OF THIS CHAPTER

The 2023 English block was **10 vocabulary + 5 para jumbles + 5 comprehension** (PYQ-DERIVED, Blueprint §4.4). On that evidence, **grammar was not separately tested at all**.

So why a chapter at all, and why 30 questions?

Because grammar is the **supporting format**. It is the layer underneath the three formats that *were* tested: a fill-in-the-blank vocabulary item is often decided by which option is grammatically possible in the slot (F8.1 §2.4), and a para jumble is solved by pronoun reference and connective logic, which is grammar under another name (F8.2 §3.1). Every mark this chapter protects is a mark in another chapter.

What follows from that is a decision about depth. This chapter is written to be **finished quickly** — dense rule tables and heavy practice, with no teaching of parts of speech from zero. The patterns are finite, they recur, and once recognised they are recognised for good. Budget **two evenings**, not four, and do not let it displace the vocabulary drip.

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0. How This Chapter Works

STUDY SESSION · CHAPTER F8.4

1. **Session 1** — The three formats, and what is actually being tested (§1) ★★☆☆
2. **Session 2** — Subject-verb agreement (§2) ★★★★★
3. **Session 3** — Tense and the sequence of tenses (§3) ★★★★★
4. **Session 4** — Prepositions and idiomatic usage (§4) ★★★★★
5. **Session 5** — Pronouns, modifiers and parallelism (§5) ★★★★★
6. **Session 6** — Articles, degree and the standard redundancies (§6) ★★★★★

Then 30 graded questions in §7. F8.0's calendar takes §7 Q1–15 on Monday of week 2 and Q16–30 on Wednesday of week 2, re-drills the whole bank in week 4, works the errors only in week 6, and takes all 30 timed in week 10.

MUST MASTER · WHERE THE MARKS ACTUALLY ARE IN THIS CHAPTER

Of the six sessions, **two carry most of the value:**

- **§2, subject-verb agreement.** The single most productive error type in Indian competitive English,

because the examiner can hide the subject behind an intervening phrase and the sentence still *sounds* right. Learn the twelve rules in §2 properly

- **§4, prepositions.** Not deducible from logic — *differ from* a thing but *differ with* a person, for

no reason at all. It is vocabulary wearing a grammatical coat, and it must be memorised as pairs

§3, §5 and §6 are pattern recognition and go faster. If your time collapses, do §2 and §4 and skip straight to the practice.

1. Session 1 — The Three Formats ★★☆☆☆

1.1 What you will be shown

Format	What it looks like	What it is really testing
Error spotting	A sentence in four labelled parts; name the part containing the error	Whether you can locate an error, not merely feel one
Sentence improvement	One part underlined; choose the best replacement, or <i>no improvement</i>	The same rules, in reverse
Fill in the blank	A gap needing a preposition, a verb form or a connective	Prepositions and tense, mostly

1.2 The method for error spotting

MUST MASTER · CHECK IN THIS ORDER, AND STOP WHEN YOU FIND IT

Do not read the sentence for meaning and wait for something to feel wrong. Feeling is unreliable, because a wrong sentence you have heard a hundred times feels right. Run the checklist instead — it takes about twenty seconds:

1. **Find the true subject, and check the verb agrees with it.** Ignore everything between them
2. **Check the tense sequence** — especially if one clause is past and another is not
3. **Check every preposition** against §4
4. **Check every pronoun** for a clear antecedent and correct case
5. **Check the comparative** — *than* with a comparative, *to* with *superior* / *inferior* / *senior* / *preferable*
6. **Check for a redundancy** — *return back*, *discuss about*, *more better*, *cousin brother*

Rule one, since there is nearly always exactly one error: when you find a definite error, mark it and move on. Do not audit the remaining parts. That discipline is what brings this format inside its 30–40 second budget (F8.0 §1.1).

1.3 The trap that defines the format

The sentences are built so that the error is in the part that reads most naturally. "*The list of members have been placed before the Commissioner*" is wrong, and it sounds right, because *members* is sitting next to *have*. Every question in §7.1 is built on this principle: **the noun nearest the verb is usually not the subject.**

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 1

1. Name the three formats
2. State the six-step checklist in order
3. Why should you stop reading once you find a definite error?
4. What is the standard trick for hiding a subject–verb disagreement?

2. Session 2 — Subject-Verb Agreement ★★★★★

2.1 The twelve rules

#	Rule	Example
1	An intervening phrase does not change the number of the subject	The list of members has been placed
2	<i>as well as, along with, together with, in addition to, besides, accompanied by</i> — the verb follows the first subject only	The employer, along with his managers, was present
3	<i>either... or, neither... nor, not only... but also</i> — the verb agrees with the nearer subject	Neither the employer nor his representatives were present
4	<i>each, every, everyone, everybody, either, neither, none, no one, anybody, somebody</i> — singular	Each of the schemes has been framed
5	Two subjects joined by <i>and</i> take a plural verb — unless they name one thing	Bread and butter is his only meal
6	A number of = plural · the number of = singular	A number of claims are pending · The number of claims has fallen
7	A collective noun is singular when it acts as one body, plural when its members act individually	The committee is unanimous · The committee are divided
8	Money, distance, time and weight taken as a single amount are singular	Ten years is a long time · ₹50,000 is a heavy penalty
9	Plural-looking singulars: news, mathematics, physics, economics, statistics (<i>the subject</i>), politics, measles, innings, summons	The news of the recovery was welcomed
10	Singular-looking plurals: police, people, cattle, gentry, vermin, poultry, clergy	The police have registered a case
11	One of the + plural noun + who / that + plural verb — the relative refers to the plural noun	He is one of the officers who are willing to dissent
12	<i>There is / there are</i> agrees with what follows it	There are three schemes under the Act

TRAP · THE FOUR THAT ARE MISSED MOST OFTEN

1. **Rule 2 versus Rule 3.** *Along with* leaves the number alone; *neither... nor* moves it to the nearer subject. Two phrases that look similar and behave in opposite ways, and the examiner will put them in adjacent questions. See Q2 and Q28
2. **Rule 6.** *A number of* and *the number of* differ by one article and take different verbs. Q5 and Q22 both use it
3. **Rule 11.** *One of those who* takes a **plural** verb, which sounds wrong to almost everyone. The subject of the relative clause is *those / the officers*, not *one*. Q25
4. **Rule 9.** *Statistics* is singular as a subject of study (*statistics is a branch of mathematics*) and plural as a set of figures (*the statistics were revised*). Both are correct, in different senses

2.2 The mechanical drill

Cover the verb, ask "**who or what?**" once, answer in one word, then restore the verb. "*The list ... has.*" "*The number ... has.*" "*The police ... have.*"

This works because the checklist step is mechanical and the intuition is not. Practise it on ten sentences and it becomes automatic.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 2

1. Recite the twelve rules
2. Why does *along with* behave differently from *neither... nor*?
3. Give the verb for: *a number of claims*, *the number of claims*
4. Why does *one of the officers who* take a plural verb?
5. Which of *police*, *news*, *cattle*, *mathematics* take plural verbs?

3. Session 3 — Tense and Sequence ★★★★★

3.1 The rules that get tested

Rule	Right	Wrong
since / for with a period reaching the present take the present perfect	He has been in service since 2015	He is in service since 2015
Past principal clause » past subordinate clause	He said that he would submit the report	He said that he will submit
Exception: a universal truth stays in the present	He said that water boils at 100 °C	He said that water boiled
The earlier of two past actions takes the past perfect	The employer had left before the inspector arrived	The employer left before the inspector had arrived
<i>no sooner... than* · *hardly / scarcely... when</i>	No sooner had the order been passed than he appealed	No sooner... when · Hardly... than
After if, unless, until, when, before, after, as soon as, a future is expressed by the present	If the employer remits the arrears, no penalty will follow	If the employer will remit
It is time / it is high time + past tense	It is time the employer paid the arrears	It is time the employer pays
<i>wish, as if, as though* + *were</i>	He speaks as if he were the Commissioner	as if he was
would rather + bare infinitive	He would rather resign than accept a transfer	would rather to resign

MUST MASTER · THE THREE HIGHEST-FREQUENCY TENSE ERRORS

1. **"Since" with a simple present.** *He is working here since 2015* is the commonest Indian English error in the language, and it is wrong in every register. *Since* fixes a starting point, which requires a **perfect** tense: **has been working**
2. **The reported-speech shift.** *He said that he will submit* must be *would submit*. A past reporting verb pulls the reported verb back one step — unless what is reported is timelessly true
3. **No sooner... than and hardly... when.** These are fixed pairs and the examiner swaps them. *No sooner* takes **than**; *hardly* and *scarcely* take **when**. Both invert: *No sooner **had** the order been passed...*

3.2 The perfect infinitive

After *hoped*, *intended*, *expected*, *wanted*, *meant* about something that **did not happen**, use the perfect infinitive: *I had hoped **to have finished** the inquiry by March*. Rare, but distinctive when it appears.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 3

1. Correct: *He is in service since 2015*
2. What happens to a reported verb when the reporting verb is past? What is the exception?
3. Complete: *No sooner had the order been passed _____*
4. Give the verb form after *it is time* and after *as if*

4. Session 4 — Prepositions and Idiomatic Usage ★★★★★

Nothing here is deducible. It is a memory list, and it is the highest-yield memory list in the English block after the vocabulary itself.

4.1 The pairs that change meaning with the preposition

Verb	One preposition	The other
differ	from a thing	with a person (on a point)
consist	of its parts	in its essence
die	of a disease	from a cause · for a cause
accompanied	by a person	with a thing
confide	in a person (trust)	to a person (disclose)
entrust	a person with a task	a task to a person
provide	for a contingency	a person with a thing
agree	to a proposal	with a person
charge	a person with an offence	a sum to an account
enter	a room — no preposition	into an agreement
responsible	to a person	for a matter
liable	for a sum	to a penalty

4.2 The fixed prepositions worth memorising

Take to: superior, inferior, senior, junior, prior, subsequent, preferable, entitled, averse, addicted, akin, indifferent, consent, accede, yield, object.

Take with: comply, dispense, part, cope, acquaint, tamper, vie, deal, correspond (*a person*), familiar, conversant, entrusted (*a task*).

Take of: deprive, accuse, convict, suspect, apprised, cognisant, dispose (*get rid of*), beware.

Take from: abstain, refrain, prohibit, exempt, absolve, derive, recover (*an amount*).

Take for: eligible, liable (*a sum*), compensate, account, atone, opt, apologise (*to a person for a thing*).

Take on / upon: insist, depend, rely, impose, embark, congratulate (*on*), act.

Take *in*: invest, succeed, persist, involved, absorbed, interfere (*in a matter*) — but **interfere with** a thing or a person.

MUST MASTER · THE VERBS THAT TAKE NO PREPOSITION AT ALL

This is the most reliably examined item in the whole session, because the wrong version is what everyone says out loud.

Never followed by a preposition: **discuss** (not *discuss about*), **describe**, **order**, **resemble**, **accompany**, **emphasise**, **comprise** (not *comprise of*), **reach** (not *reach at*), **await** (not *await for*), **lack** (not *lack of*, as a verb), **attack**, **investigate**, **demand**, **request**, **join**, **sign**, **stress**, **precede**.

And the reverse — **verbs that always need one:** *listen **to***, *reply **to***, *wait **for***, *hope **for***, *dispose **of***, *aim **at***, *insist **on***, *dispense **with***, *comply **with***.

Two that are worth their own line: *comprise* means *is made up of*, so "**comprises of**" says "**is made up of of**". And **prefer** takes **to**, never *than*: *he prefers the pension **to** the withdrawal benefit*. *Preferable* likewise takes *to*.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 4

1. Give both prepositions, with meanings, for *differ*, *consist*, *entrust*, *provide*
2. Which preposition follows *superior*, *preferable*, *entitled*, *averse*?
3. Name eight verbs that take no preposition
4. What is wrong with *comprises of*? With *prefer than*?

5. Session 5 — Pronouns, Modifiers and Parallelism ★★★★★

5.1 Pronouns

Rule	Right	Wrong
After a preposition, the object form	between you and me · for you and me	between you and I
After <i>than</i> or <i>as</i>, the subject form (a verb is understood)	He is senior to me, but I am older than he (is)	older than him (<i>in formal use</i>)
<i>Each, every, everyone, anyone, none</i> take a singular pronoun	Everyone must sign his own declaration	Everyone must sign their own
A reflexive cannot be a subject, and needs an antecedent	The Commissioner and I examined the file	The Commissioner and myself examined
<i>Who</i> for the subject, <i>whom</i> for the object	the officer who signed · the officer whom we heard	
A pronoun needs one unmistakable antecedent	<i>The employer told the inspector that the employer's records were missing</i>	<i>...that his records were missing — whose?</i>

5.2 Misplaced and dangling modifiers

MUST MASTER · THE PARTICIPLE MUST BELONG TO THE SUBJECT THAT FOLLOWS IT

When a sentence opens with a participial phrase, **the subject of the main clause must be the thing doing the participle.**

Wrong: *Having examined the registers, the discrepancy was obvious.* The discrepancy did not examine anything.

Right: *Having examined the registers, the inspector found the discrepancy obvious.*

The repair is always the same: **make the doer the subject.** Q23 is exactly this shape, and the option that reads most smoothly is the one with no doer at all.

And the placement of *only*. It modifies whatever follows it, so it changes the meaning of the sentence depending on position: *Only the Commissioner can condone* (nobody else) · *The Commissioner can only condone* (he can do nothing else) · *The Commissioner can condone only the delay* (nothing else can be condoned). Where an option moves *only*, ask which meaning the sentence needs.

5.3 Parallelism

Items joined by *and*, *or*, or a correlative pair must be the **same grammatical kind**.

Wrong	Right
The report was not only late but also it was incomplete	not only late but also incomplete (<i>adjective, adjective</i>)
He is responsible for the inquiry and to submit a report	for the inquiry and for submitting a report
She likes auditing and to prepare accounts	auditing and preparing

Correlatives keep their partners: *not only... but also* · *either... or* · *neither... nor* · *both... and* · *not... but* · *no sooner... than*. Mixing partners (*neither... or*, *both... as well as*) is an error.

5.4 Two constructions that are always wrong

- **The reason is because.** *Reason* already means *because*. Write **the reason is that**
- **The double negative.** *Hardly*, *scarcely*, *barely*, *seldom* are already negative, so **hardly no evidence** and *cannot hardly* are wrong. Use **hardly any**

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 5

1. *Between you and ___? Older than ___?*
2. What must be true of the subject following an opening participial phrase?
3. Give the three meanings produced by moving *only* in one sentence
4. Correct: *not only late but also it was incomplete*
5. What is wrong with *the reason is because* and with *hardly no evidence*?

6. Session 6 — Articles, Degree and Redundancy ★★★★★

6.1 Articles

- **A or an follows sound, not spelling:** a university, a one-rupee coin, a European —

an hour, an honest officer, an MP, an LLB

- **The** before superlatives, unique things, rivers, ranges, oceans, plural country names, and a singular noun standing for a whole class: *the Ganga, the Himalayas, the United States, the tiger is disappearing*

- **No article** before abstract nouns, material nouns, meals, languages or games in their general sense: *honesty pays · gold is costly · he plays cricket · he teaches English*

- **One article for one person, two for two:** *the Secretary and Commissioner* is one officer; **the Secretary and the Commissioner** is two

6.2 Degree of comparison

Rule	Note
No double comparative or superlative	<i>more better, most unkindest</i> are wrong
<i>Superior, inferior, senior, junior, prior, preferable*</i> take <i>*to</i>	never <i>than</i>
Absolute adjectives take no degree	<i>unique, perfect, complete, extreme, ideal, universal</i> — no <i>more unique</i>
<i>Comparatively</i> and <i>relatively</i> take the positive degree	<i>comparatively easy</i> , not <i>comparatively easier</i>
<i>Elder / eldest</i> for family, attributively	<i>my elder brother</i> ; but <i>older than</i>
<i>Later / latest</i> = time · <i>latter / last</i> = position	
<i>Farther</i> = distance · <i>further</i> = additional	
<i>Fewer</i> = number · <i>less</i> = quantity	fewer defaults, less money
One of the + superlative + plural noun	one of the best officers

6.3 The standard redundancies

Each of these says the same thing twice, and each appears in error-spotting banks:

return back · revert back · repeat again · discuss about · comprise of · cousin brother · more preferable · both the twins · reason is because · sufficient enough · new innovation · final conclusion · mutual cooperation · descend down · rise up · join together · free gift · past history · advance planning

THINK LIKE UPSC · WHY THIS SESSION IS SHORT ON PURPOSE

Articles and degree are the parts of English grammar with the longest rule lists and the smallest examination yield. A full treatment of the article would run to twenty pages and win you, on the 2023 evidence, nothing.

What is in §6 is the residue that actually appears in question banks: the sound rule for *a / an*, the *to* comparatives, absolute adjectives, *fewer* against *less*, and the redundancy list. **That is the whole of it, and it is enough.**

Blueprint §10.2's instruction that Module 8 must never become a block applies inside the module too: this is the point at which grammar stops earning and the vocabulary drip resumes.

CHECK YOURSELF · SESSION 6

1. *A* or *an*: university, hour, MP, one-rupee coin, honest officer
2. Which comparatives take *to* instead of *than*?
3. Why is *most unique* wrong?
4. *Fewer* or *less*: defaults, money, claims, interest
5. Name eight redundancies from §6.3

7. Graded Practice — 30 Questions ★★★★★

Target: 30 to 40 seconds each. Run the §1.2 checklist rather than waiting for something to sound wrong. In §7.1 each sentence is divided into four parts; name the part containing the error.

7.1 Level 1 — Error spotting

- Q1.** The list of members whose contributions are in arrears **(a)** / have been placed before **(b)** / the Commissioner for orders **(c)** / under Section 7A of the Act. **(d)**
- Q2.** Neither the employer **(a)** / nor his two authorised representatives **(b)** / was present **(c)** / at the hearing held last Tuesday. **(d)**
- Q3.** Each of the three schemes have **(a)** / been framed under the Act **(b)** / by the Central Government **(c)** / in exercise of the powers conferred on it. **(d)**
- Q4.** The employer asked **(a)** / the Commissioner **(b)** / to dispense with the requirement **(c)** / and to discuss about the matter in his chamber. **(d)**
- Q5.** The number of establishments **(a)** / covered by the Act **(b)** / have risen sharply **(c)** / in the last decade. **(d)**
- Q6.** Hardly had the inspection begun than **(a)** / the employer produced **(b)** / a set of registers **(c)** / that had not been mentioned earlier. **(d)**
- Q7.** The auditor stated that **(a)** / he will submit **(b)** / his report before **(c)** / the end of the financial year. **(d)**
- Q8.** The Commissioner directed **(a)** / the employer to remit **(b)** / the arrears with interest **(c)** / and to return back the registers seized during the inspection. **(d)**
- Q9.** Every one of the **(a)** / documents seized **(b)** / during the inspection were **(c)** / produced at the hearing. **(d)**
- Q10.** Between you and I, **(a)** / the explanation offered **(b)** / by the employer **(c)** / was hardly convincing. **(d)**

7.2 Level 2 — Prepositions and sentence improvement

- Q11.** The two provisions differ _____ each other in one respect only. (a) with (b) to (c) against (d) from
- Q12.** The inquiry into the default was entrusted _____ an Assistant Provident Fund Commissioner. (a) to (b) with (c) for (d) of
- Q13.** The gravity of the offence consists _____ the deliberate withholding of contributions already deducted. (a) of (b) with (c) in (d) from
- Q14.** A member who has contributed for the required period is entitled _____ the pension as a matter of right. (a) to (b) for (c) of (d) with
- Q15.** The Scheme **comprises of** three distinct components. Choose the best replacement for the words in bold. (a) is comprised in (b) comprises (c) comprise of (d) No improvement

- Q16.** *He would rather resign **than to accept** a transfer.* Choose the best replacement for the words in bold. (a) than accepting (b) rather than to accept (c) than he accepts (d) than accept
- Q17.** *It is high time the employer **pays** the arrears.* Choose the best replacement for the word in bold. (a) has paid (b) will pay (c) paid (d) No improvement
- Q18.** *Neither of the two explanations **are** satisfactory.* Choose the best replacement for the word in bold. (a) is (b) were (c) have been (d) No improvement
- Q19.** The inspector insisted _____ examining the original wage registers. (a) to (b) for (c) on (d) about
- Q20.** *The report was not only late **but also it was incomplete**.* Choose the best replacement for the words in bold. (a) but also incomplete it was (b) but also incomplete (c) but incomplete also (d) No improvement

7.3 Level 3 — Recruitment Test standard

- Q21.** Which one of the following sentences is grammatically correct? (a) The police have registered a case against the employer. (b) The police has registered a case against the employer. (c) The police is registering a case against the employer. (d) The police was registering a case against the employer.
- Q22.** Which one of the following sentences is **not** correct? (a) The number of claims pending has fallen this year. (b) A number of claims are still pending before the authority. (c) Ten thousand rupees is a substantial penalty for the default. (d) The news of the recoveries were welcomed by the Board.
- Q23.** Choose the option that correctly completes the sentence: *Having examined the wage registers, _____* (a) the discrepancy was obvious at once (b) it was obvious that a discrepancy existed (c) the inspector found the discrepancy obvious (d) the discrepancy became obvious to everyone
- Q24.** Which one of the following sentences is correct? (a) He is senior than me in the service. (b) He is senior to me in the service. (c) He is more senior than me in the service. (d) He is senior from me in the service.
- Q25.** He is one of the few officers who _____ willing to record a dissent. (a) are (b) is (c) was (d) has been
- Q26.** Choose the option that correctly completes the sentence: *No sooner had the order been passed _____* (a) when the employer filed an appeal (b) then the employer filed an appeal (c) than the employer had filed an appeal (d) than the employer filed an appeal
- Q27.** Choose the option that correctly completes the sentence: *The Commissioner asked the employer why _____* (a) had he not remitted the contributions (b) did he not remit the contributions (c) he had not remitted the contributions (d) has he not remitted the contributions
- Q28.** Which one of the following sentences is correct? (a) The employer, along with his two managers, was present at the hearing. (b) The employer, along with his two managers, were present at the hearing. (c) The employer along with his two managers have been present at the hearing. (d) The employer along with his two managers are present at the hearing.
- Q29.** There were _____ defaults this year than last, and consequently _____ money had to be recovered by coercive process. (a) less ... fewer (b) fewer ... less (c) less ... less (d) fewer ... fewer
- Q30.** Which one of the following sentences is **not** correct? (a) The two schemes are different from each other in scope. (b) He has been in service since 2015. (c) The committee is unanimous in its recommendation. (d) This is the most unique instance of default in the region.

8. Answers and Explanations

8.1 Level 1 — Error spotting

Q	Ans	Explanation
1	b	has been placed. The subject is the list , not <i>members</i> — §2.1 rule 1. The intervening phrase is there precisely so that a plural noun sits next to the verb
2	c	were present. With <i>neither... nor</i> the verb agrees with the nearer subject, here <i>representatives</i> — rule 3. Contrast Q28, where <i>along with</i> leaves the number alone
3	a	has been framed. <i>Each of</i> is singular — rule 4 — whatever follows it
4	d	to discuss the matter. <i>Discuss</i> takes no preposition (§4.2). The commonest spoken error in the list, which is why it is set
5	c	has risen. <i>The number of</i> is singular ; <i>a number of</i> would be plural — rule 6. One article decides the verb
6	a	Hardly had the inspection begun when. <i>Hardly</i> and <i>scarcely</i> pair with when ; only <i>no sooner</i> takes <i>than</i> (§3.1). Compare Q26
7	b	he would submit. A past reporting verb (<i>stated</i>) pulls the reported verb back — §3.2's second point. The report is not a universal truth, so the exception does not apply
8	d	to return the registers. <i>Return back</i> is a redundancy (§6.3) — <i>return</i> already contains <i>back</i>
9	c	was produced. <i>Every one of</i> is singular — rule 4. Note that <i>every one</i> here is two words, meaning each individually; <i>everyone</i> would refer to people
10	a	Between you and me. <i>Between</i> is a preposition, so it takes the object form — §5.1. The temptation towards <i>I</i> comes from over-correction

8.2 Level 2 — Prepositions and improvement

Q	Ans	Explanation
11	d	differ from. Things differ from each other; you differ with a person, on a point — §4.1
12	b	entrusted with. A person is entrusted with a task; a task is entrusted to a person. Here the officer is entrusted, so <i>with</i> . This pair is worth memorising in both directions
13	c	consists in. *Consist in = has its essence in ; * consist of = is made up of. The gravity of an offence is its essence, not its parts
14	a	entitled to. One of the fixed <i>to</i> list in §4.2, alongside <i>superior, inferior, senior, preferable, averse</i>
15	b	comprises. <i>Comprise</i> means <i>is made up of</i> , so <i>comprises of</i> says <i>is made up of of</i> . Note (a) is a real construction — <i>is comprised in</i> — but it means <i>is included in</i> , which reverses the sense
16	d	than accept. <i>Would rather</i> takes the bare infinitive on both sides of <i>than</i> — §3.1
17	c	paid. <i>It is time</i> and <i>it is high time</i> take the past form, this being a subjunctive of unreality rather than a past tense
18	a	is. <i>Neither of</i> is singular — rule 4. <i>Of the two</i> does not make it plural
19	c	insisted on. <i>Insist</i> takes on ; <i>insist to</i> and <i>insist about</i> do not exist
20	b	but also incomplete. <i>Not only... but also</i> must join like with like : here adjective with adjective, <i>late</i> with <i>incomplete</i> — §5.3. Repeating the subject and verb breaks the parallel

8.3 Level 3 — Recruitment Test standard

Q	Ans	Explanation
21	a	The police have. <i>Police</i> is a singular-looking plural, with <i>people, cattle, gentry, clergy, vermin, poultry</i> — rule 10. All three wrong options use a singular verb
22	d	The news... were is wrong; <i>news</i> is a plural-looking singular — rule 9. Note that (a), (b) and (c) are all correct, and each illustrates a different rule: <i>the number of</i> singular, <i>a number of</i> plural, and <i>money as a single amount</i> singular. The stem asks which is NOT correct
23	c	Only (c) supplies a subject that did the examining — §5.2. (a), (b) and (d) all make the discrepancy or an impersonal <i>it</i> the subject, so the participle dangles. (b) is the smoothest-reading of the wrong options, which is exactly why it is offered
24	b	senior to. <i>Superior, inferior, senior, junior, prior, preferable</i> take to , never <i>than</i> — §6.2. (c) adds a second error: <i>senior</i> is already comparative, so <i>more senior</i> is a double comparative
25	a	who are. The relative clause describes <i>the few officers</i> , not <i>one</i> — rule 11. This is the agreement rule that sounds wrong to nearly everyone and is therefore examined
26	d	than the employer filed. <i>No sooner</i> takes than (compare Q6's <i>hardly... when</i>), and the second clause takes the simple past , not the past perfect — the past perfect already sits in the first clause
27	c	In indirect speech there is no inversion and no auxiliary fronting: <i>asked... why he had not remitted</i> . The reporting verb is past, so the reported verb goes back one step to the past perfect
28	a	was present. <i>Along with</i> does not change the number of the subject — rule 2, and the deliberate contrast with Q2. The subject is <i>the employer</i> , singular
29	b	fewer defaults, less money. <i>Fewer</i> counts, <i>less</i> measures — §6.2. Defaults can be counted; money as an amount cannot
30	d	Most unique is wrong: <i>unique</i> is an absolute adjective and admits no degree — §6.2. (a), (b) and (c) are all correct — <i>differ from</i> a thing, <i>since</i> with the present perfect, and a collective noun acting as one body taking a singular verb

THINK LIKE UPSC · THE FIVE SHAPES IN THIS BANK

1. **The hidden subject.** Q1, Q3, Q5, Q9, Q18, Q25, Q28. **Seven of thirty questions** turn on finding the true subject through an intervening phrase. Nothing else in this chapter comes close in frequency
2. **The matched pair, swapped.** Q2 against Q28 (*neither... nor* against *along with*); Q6 against Q26 (*hardly... when* against *no sooner... than*); Q5's *the number of* against Q22's *a number of*. The examiner sets both members of a pair and relies on you knowing only one
3. **The redundancy you say out loud.** Q4 and Q8. *Discuss about* and *return back* are so common in speech that they read as correct. Learn §6.3 as a list of forbidden phrases, not as a rule
4. **The "not correct" stem.** Q22 and Q30. About **20% of the 2023 paper** used this format (Blueprint §6), and here the three *correct* options are the distractors. **Re-read the stem before you mark**
5. **The smooth wrong option.** Q23(b). Where a dangling modifier is the issue, the option that avoids naming a doer will always read most easily, because it hides the problem rather than fixing it

9. One-Minute Revision

ONE-MINUTE REVISION · CHAPTER F8.4

WEIGHT not separately tested in 2023 · it is the **supporting layer** under vocabulary blanks and para jumbles · **target 30–40 seconds** · budget two evenings, not four

CHECKLIST 1 true subject vs verb **2** tense sequence **3** every preposition **4** every pronoun **5** the comparative **6** redundancy. **Stop at the first definite error**

AGREEMENT intervening phrase changes nothing · *along with / as well as / besides* » **first subject only** · *either–or, neither–nor* » **nearer subject** · *each, every, either, neither, none* » **singular** · **a number of = plural, THE number of = singular** · collective singular when acting as one · money/time/distance as one amount **singular** · **news, mathematics, statistics, innings, summons = singular** · **police, people, cattle, gentry, clergy = plural** · **one of those who + PLURAL verb** · *there is / are* follows what comes next

TENSE *since / for* » **present perfect**, never simple present · past reporting verb » reported verb back one step, **except a universal truth** · earlier past action » **past perfect** · **no sooner... THAN** · **hardly / scarcely... WHEN** · after *if / until / when / as soon as*, the future is expressed by the present · *it is time + past* · *as if / wish + were* · *would rather + bare infinitive*

PREPOSITION PAIRS differ **from** a thing / **with** a person · consist **of** parts / **in** essence · die **of** disease / **from** a cause · accompanied **by** a person / **with** a thing · entrust a person **with** / a task **to** · provide **for** a contingency / a person **with** · responsible **to** a person / **for** a matter · liable **for** a sum / **to** a penalty

TAKE *TO superior · inferior · senior · junior · prior · preferable · entitled · averse · accede
TAKE *WITH comply · dispense · cope · acquaint · tamper · vie · conversant **NO PREPOSITION**
 discuss · describe · order · resemble · accompany · emphasise · comprise · reach · await · attack · investigate · request · sign **PREFER TAKES TO, NEVER THAN**

PRONOUNS *between you and me* · *older than he (is)* · everyone » **his** · a reflexive is never a subject · *who* subject, *whom* object

MODIFIERS an opening participle must belong to the **subject that follows** · *only* modifies whatever comes after it

PARALLELISM *not only... but also* joins like with like · keep correlative partners: *neither... nor, both... and, either... or* · **the reason is THAT**, not *because* · no double negative after *hardly*

DEGREE no double comparative · **absolutes take no degree: unique, perfect, complete, ideal** · *comparatively* + positive · **fewer counts, less measures** · elder/older · later/latter · farther/further

REDUNDANCIES return back · revert back · repeat again · discuss about · comprise of · cousin brother · more preferable · reason is because · sufficient enough · new innovation · descend

down · past history

10. Five-Minute Wall Sheet

FIVE-MINUTE WALL SHEET · CHAPTER F8.4

FIND THE SUBJECT. IGNORE EVERYTHING BETWEEN IT AND THE VERB

THE LIST ... HAS · THE NUMBER OF ... HAS · A NUMBER OF ... HAVE · THE POLICE ... HAVE · THE NEWS ... WAS

ALONG WITH » FIRST SUBJECT · NEITHER–NOR » NEARER SUBJECT

EACH · EVERY · EITHER · NEITHER · NONE » SINGULAR

ONE OF THOSE WHO » PLURAL VERB

SINCE » HAS BEEN, NEVER IS

HE SAID HE *WOULD*, NOT *WILL*

NO SOONER ... THAN · HARDLY / SCARCELY ... WHEN

IT IS TIME HE *PAID* · AS IF HE *WERE* · WOULD RATHER *RESIGN*

DIFFER FROM A THING, WITH A PERSON · CONSIST OF PARTS, IN ESSENCE

SENIOR / SUPERIOR / INFERIOR / PREFERABLE / ENTITLED » *TO*

DISCUSS · COMPRISE · REACH · RESEMBLE · AWAIT » NO PREPOSITION

BETWEEN YOU AND *ME*

THE PARTICIPLE MUST HAVE A DOER: *HAVING EXAMINED ...*, *THE INSPECTOR FOUND*

NOT ONLY LATE BUT ALSO *INCOMPLETE* — like with like

FEWER DEFAULTS · LESS MONEY

NOTHING IS *MORE UNIQUE*

RETURN BACK · DISCUSS ABOUT · COMPRISE OF · REASON IS BECAUSE » ALL WRONG

ONE LINE FOR THE INTERVIEW Grammar in this paper is rarely tested for its own sake, but it decides the vocabulary blanks and the para jumbles — a wrong option can often be eliminated because it cannot fit the slot grammatically, before you have considered its meaning at all.

ACTION · NEXT

The English half of Module 8 is now complete: **F8.1 vocabulary, F8.2 para jumbles, F8.3 comprehension, F8.4 grammar** — 110 questions covering all 20 of the English marks observed in 2023.

Next: F8.5 — Arithmetic. Ratio, percentage, average, ages, mixtures and time and work, which between them supplied a third of the 2023 Quant block.

Tonight's drill, per F8.0's week 2 Monday cell: **\$7 Q1–15, timed at ten minutes.**